

Dual VENUE Systems Bolster Guns N' Roses Live Shows

Rock fans have been waiting 14 years for the return of frontman **Axl Rose** and his band **Guns N' Roses**, and with the band's new tour in full swing, devotees worldwide are finally getting the chance to see their idols up close and personal once again.

With a hit-filled set that also includes some new songs from the band's forthcoming and long-awaited album, *Chinese Democracy*, Guns N' Roses is currently on tour through North America.

To handle the live shows, audio veteran **Toby Francis** was tapped for FOH (duties, **Andy Ebert** was selected for monitors, and the **Digidesign VENUE** live sound environment was chosen to run the show. With two VENUE D-Show systems in tow for FOH and monitor mixes, Francis and Ebert are wrangling around 70 inputs nightly, but both are thrilled with the VENUE system's ease of use and superior sound quality. And the band is happy to hear the same sounds they're used to getting in the studio on a nightly basis.

"This is what I've wanted for years," exclaims Francis. "I've tried everything-at least demoed everything. This is the first console I've wanted to own. I've always looked at the others as a temporary step. Even though some of them I used for four or five years, I was just waiting for technology to advance."

Francis knew that Digidesign products were the way to go after he completed his first Pro Tools mix session. "I wanted to go that route," he says. "We toyed with trying to do live sound on a [Digidesign] ProControl, but it just wasn't right-logistically-but I wanted to use the plug-ins."

When he first discovered VENUE, Francis was initially impressed with its user-friendly accessibility. "I didn't even read the manual!" he laughs. "Actually I did use the manual to learn how to turn it on and off and the rest was self explanatory. I have a Pro Tools background so the transition was natural, but again, everybody that's been on it has said the same thing-it's not overly complicated. Compared to everything else that's out there, it gets the job done [even if] there are less pages, less stuff to go through-and it's laid out really well. But I'll tell you, the sound of it is what I think is selling people on it."

Ebert agrees: "I had used digital consoles before, but I never really liked them because of their sound quality and the fact that they're so complicated to operate. What I'm looking for in a digital console is something that's the most like analog. From the first second I got on the VENUE, I got around on it really, really well and [it was] easy, which was great! Everything's easy to locate and it's very convenient. I downloaded the software a few months ago-prepared everything with the software-so I knew a little about the surface already before I went on tour with it. But the most amazing thing about the VENUE is it sounds great."

Francis claims that once you try VENUE, there's no going back to anything else. "The thing I like most about VENUE is the sound of it," he says. "It's the best sounding of all of the consoles I've tried. Every engineer that's been on it has said the same thing, too. It sounds so punchy! There's not a big difference changing from analog to digital. The overall sound is very similar. Plus, you get all the extra features that you don't get with analog gear." <> With VENUE, Francis also gets his plug-ins since the system uses the same type of TDM plug-ins as Pro Tools|HD® systems. With the wide range of onboard plug-ins available for VENUE, he estimates that he's eliminated around 60 rack spaces of superfluous outboard gear. His current favorite plug-ins are emulations of older compressors and EQs, such as ones from Pultec.

"[Guns N' Roses] rhythm guitarist Richard Fortus asked me what plug-in I was using on his guitar and was blown away that it was the same one he used in the studio," recalls Francis. "This is when I first started working for Guns N' Roses, and it helped us get a rapport going. Bassist Tommy Stinson pulled me aside last night and said, 'This is



Toby Francis



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Rose Brand



awesome-I had the monitor engineer [Ebert] put a Fairchild plug-in on my bass and it sounds just like it does at home! I got the same thing in my ears that I'm used to hearing.'

"All these guys are studio guys; they all do sessions constantly and they all speak Digidesign. That's a neat thing. It's made it easier for the guys to relate to what we're doing. The worlds are coming together. It's neat, too, with the playback via Virtual Soundcheck because if there's anything that needs to be refined, I can bring band members out-or a tech-and show them what the mix sounds like. It's another tool to help everybody work toward the same common goal."

 www.digidesign.com

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